

BUILT FOR SPEED

The cheetah is the fastest land mammal on Earth – it can run at 113 km/h (70 mph). Strong muscles, large lungs, and a large heart mean it can take in lots of oxygen very fast and so accelerate very quickly. It has to rest after about 20–60 seconds.

**A CHEETAH CAN
CLOSE IN ON ITS
PREY IN JUST
60 SECONDS**



1 STARTING LEAP

A cheetah can run fast over short distances only. It stalks its prey until it is very close, then suddenly rushes out of cover.



2 STRAIGHTENING OUT

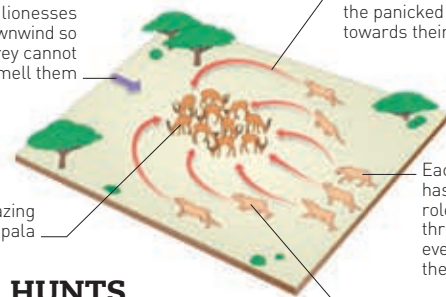
The cheetah's unusually long and flexible spine means it can cover 7–8 m (23–26 ft) in one single stride.



3 FLEXED TO LAND

The powerful back legs propel the cheetah forward so well that the back feet overtake the forefeet, ready to spring again.

Wind direction – the lionesses attack downwind so their prey cannot smell them



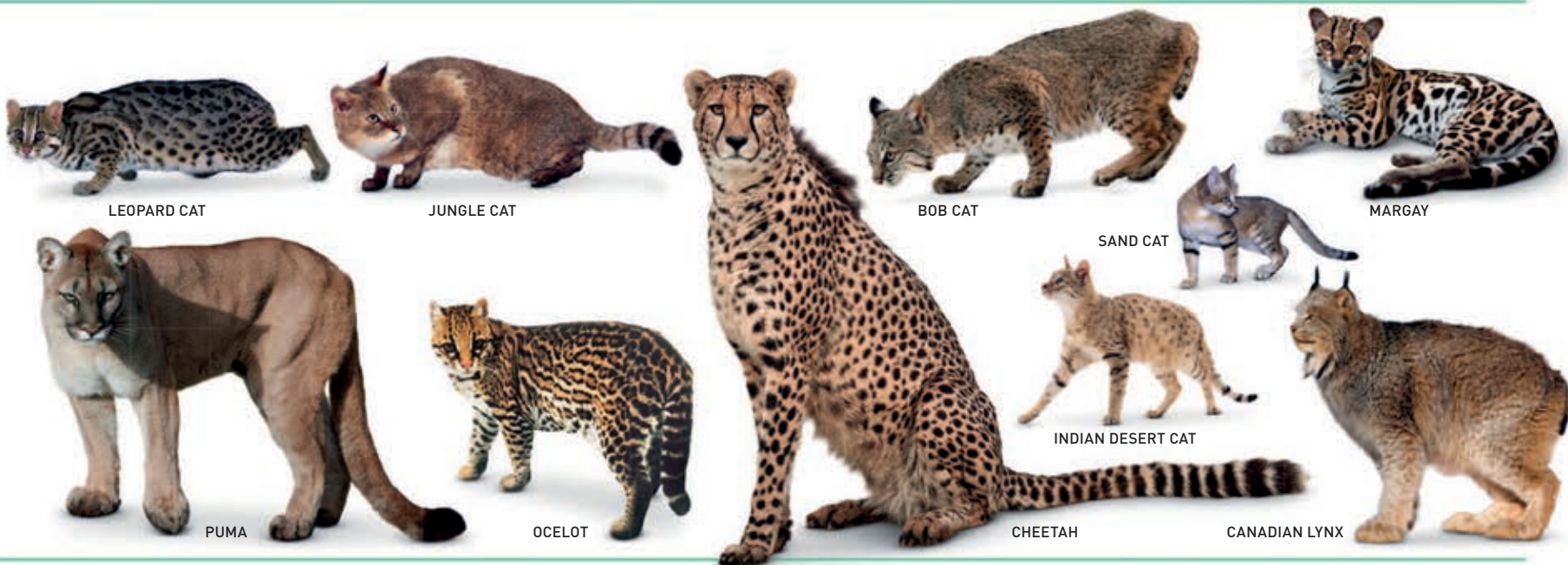
As the lionesses attack, the panicked prey run towards their predators

Each lioness has a different role. These three will eventually kill the prey

The lionesses fan out to surround their prey

LION HUNTS

Lionesses do most of the hunting. Once killed the prey is feasted upon by all that can get near enough. Youngsters usually give way to older members and all are subordinate to the males.



A tiger's stripes are unique – no two tigers will ever have the same pattern

